Animals in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: All Creatures Great and Small: Living Things in the Bible, by Edward R. Hope © 2005 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Animals, general

1 Animals, general

- 1.1 Domestic animals, cattle, livestock, animal, living being
- 1.2 Animals that are ridden or made to carry loads
- 1.3 Wild or dangerous animals

A number of words in the Bible indicate “animals” or “creatures” in a general way without specifying a particular species. Almost all languages will have one or several words for creatures that are “living” or “breathing” or “souled” (the literal meaning of the English word “animal“).

References:

Hebrew בְּהֵמָה (behemah) GEN 7:2, GEN 7:2, GEN 7:8, GEN 7:8, LEV 11:2, LEV 11:3, LEV 11:26, LEV 11:39, LEV 11:46, LEV 18:23, LEV 18:23, LEV 20:15, LEV 20:15, LEV 20:16, LEV 20:16, LEV 20:25, LEV 20:25

Hebrew חַיִּי, חַיָּה, חִיָּה (chay, chayah, cheva) GEN 1:28, GEN 1:30, GEN 6:19, GEN 8:17, LEV 11:47, LEV 11:47, PSA 104:25, DAN 2:38, DAN 4:9, DAN 4:11, DAN 4:12, DAN 4:13, DAN 4:18, DAN 4:20, DAN 4:22, DAN 4:29, DAN 5:21, DAN 7:3, DAN 7:5, DAN 7:6, DAN 7:7, DAN 7:7, DAN 7:11, DAN 7:12, DAN 7:17, DAN 7:19, DAN 7:23

Greek θήρ, θήρα (thēr) WIS 11:18, 2MA 4:25, 2MA 11:9, 3MA 5:31, 3MA 6:7

Greek ζῷον (zōon) HEB 13:11, 2PE 2:12, JUD 1:10, REV 4:6, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:7, REV 4:8, REV 4:9, REV 5:6, REV 5:8, REV 5:11, REV 5:14, REV 6:1, REV 6:3, REV 6:5, REV 6:6, REV 6:7, REV 7:11, REV 14:3, REV 15:7, REV 19:4

Greek κνώδαλον (knōdalon) WIS 11:15, WIS 16:1, WIS 17:9

Greek κτῆνος (ktēnos) 1ES 2:4, 1ES 2:6, 1ES 5:1, 1ES 8:50, 1ES 9:4, TOB 10:10, JDT 4:10, JDT 5:9, JDT 8:7, JDT 11:7, JDT 11:12, SIR 7:22, SIR 40:8, BAR 3:32, 1MA 1:47, 1MA 2:30, 1MA 2:38, 1MA 12:23

Greek τετράποδος (tetrapodos) BAR 3:32, 1MA 10:11, 4MA 1:34

Greek χερσαῖος (chersaios) WIS 19:19

Latin anima, animalis 2ES 6:47, 2ES 6:48, 2ES 11:39, 2ES 11:40

Latin bestia 2ES 5:8, 2ES 6:53, 2ES 7:65, 2ES 8:30

Latin creatura 2ES 5:45, 2ES 11:6

Latin quadrupes 2ES 7:65

Discussion:

The Hebrew word behemah carries a broad spectrum of meanings, including all of the divisions in this chapter: animal in general, domestic animal, animal that is ridden, and wild animal. This word occurs some 190 times. A few representative references have been given for this word in each category; for the most part the context will give an indication of which meaning is appropriate.

The words chay, chayah and cheva in Hebrew and zōon in Greek are derived from a root meaning “life,” “to be alive“. They can refer to any type of living creature. In some contexts the reference is to human beings in others to animals or to creatures that live in the water and in still others to all living creatures. However the reference is always to some form of animal life rather than to plants. In a few contexts the word chay functions as an adjective for example living “live” or “alive.” While the word chay does not indicate any specific animal it will usually be possible to tell from the context which animal is intended. However in some references in Genesis, Ezekiel, and Revelation there are no clues as to what kinds of animals or beings are meant. All we know is that they were alive. The words tetrapodos and quadrupes literally “four-footed” indicate animals in a general sense especially referring to mammals as opposed to snakes birds and other living creatures.

Special significance or symbolism:

In Genesis, Ezekiel, and Revelation it is clear that the “living beings” are somehow connected to God who gives life.

Translation:

In most languages a general term for something living will have to be translated differently according to the context. In contexts where the reference is clearly to people, an expression meaning “living person” is a good equivalent, while “living animal“, “living creatures”, and the like would be the best equivalents in other contexts. In some cases a general word for “animal” will be appropriate; compare the Contemporary English Version (CEV) at : “These people are no better than senseless animals. ... ” In contexts of sacrifice the preferred expressions would be “live dove“, “live goat”, or another live sacrificial animal, according to which one is identified specifically in the context.

REV 4:6: The word translated “living creatures” here means, in most contexts, “animals” but that specific meaning should not be used here. They are simply living beings, not classified either as animals or humans. They seem to be modeled after the living beings in EZK 1:5–EZK 1:14. In many cultures where there is a long Christian tradition employing a transliteration of “cherub” or “seraph” as the equivalent of “living creature” (and if translators feel that this term should continue to be employed), a footnote or a note in the glossary describing these creatures should be provided.